

Skillathon 2026 Challenge Statements

1. AI Skills Coach

Challenge

Can AI assess a student's current skills against a specific job role and create a personalised pathway to become job-ready?

Teams should demonstrate:

Student assessment → Target job role → Skill-gap analysis → Personalised learning/action plan

Potential pilot: Test the solution with a defined group of students across selected job roles and measure the usefulness and accuracy of the recommended pathways.

2. Rural Youth: Skills-to-Jobs

Challenge

How can rural Karnataka youth discover and get matched to relevant training, apprenticeships and entry-level jobs through an accessible, Multilingual Kannada-first digital interface?

Teams should demonstrate:

Youth skill profile → Kannada/English interface → Relevant training/apprenticeship/job matches → Application or referral

The solution should look beyond qualifications alone and explore how **skills, interests, location and employability** can improve matching.

Potential pilot: Test with youth from one district/institution and measure discovery, matching and application outcomes.

3. Women Returning to Work

Challenge

How can women returning after a career break identify their transferable skills, bridge skill gaps and get matched to suitable employment, apprenticeship or flexible-work opportunities?

Teams should demonstrate:

Existing skills → Career aspirations → Skill-gap identification → Reskilling pathway → Opportunity matching

Potential pilot: Work with a cohort of women returnees and demonstrate whether the solution can generate relevant and actionable pathways to employment.

4. Green Jobs & Future Skills

Challenge

How can Karnataka's youth identify emerging green jobs and understand the skills, certifications and training required to qualify for them?

Solutions can explore opportunities across sectors such as **EVs, renewable energy, energy efficiency, sustainable manufacturing and other emerging green sectors.**

Teams should demonstrate:

Emerging job roles → Required skills → Candidate assessment → Skill gaps → Training/certification pathway → Employment opportunities

Potential pilot: Map a defined set of emerging green jobs and test career/skills pathways with students or job seekers.

5. Skills Passport & Inclusive Pathways

Challenge

Can we identify people at risk of being left behind in skilling or employment, recognise the skills and experience they already have, and create personalised pathways towards training or employment?

Teams may focus on a specific target cohort such as:

- Students/trainees at risk of dropping out
- Persons with disabilities
- Informal workers
- Workers without formal qualifications
- Other underserved groups identified by Government departments

Teams should demonstrate:

Risk/needs identification → Existing skills and experience → Verified Skills Passport/Profile → Intervention or reskilling recommendation → Suitable training/employment pathway

This challenge can combine **early-warning interventions with recognition of prior skills**, rather than treating dropout prevention and employment inclusion as completely separate problems.

Potential pilot: Select one clearly defined cohort and demonstrate measurable improvement in identification, intervention, skills recognition or opportunity matching.

6. Training-to-Employment Outcomes

Challenge

How can Government and training institutions determine whether skill-development programmes are actually improving employability and leading to meaningful employment outcomes?

Teams should demonstrate:

Enrolment → Attendance → Completion → Certification → Interviews/Apprenticeships → Employment → Outcome measurement

Solutions could provide Government and institutions with actionable dashboards and insights rather than simply reporting training completion numbers.

Potential pilot: Apply the solution to one programme/cohort and demonstrate how decision-makers can track outcomes and identify areas requiring intervention.

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Our Challenge Brief

Each selected Government challenge should be converted into a simple presentable **one-two page Challenge Brief** (PDF file to be updated) which teams begin their development.

The brief should identify:

Problem Owner - Government department / agency / institution

Target User - Who actually experiences the problem?

Current Problem - What happens today and where does the process fail?

Available Resources - Data, users, institutional access or domain expertise that can be

provided

Pilot Environment - Where can the solution realistically be tested?

Success Metrics - What measurable result would constitute a successful pilot?

The final presentation should follow one simple sequence:

Problem → Solution → Prototype → Pilot → Evidence → Impact → Scale

The central question for the jury becomes:

“What did you build, who did you test it with, and what did you learn?”

Execution Timeline

22 September - 5 November 2026

Given the compressed timeline, I would **not describe this as six equal weeks** anymore. It is better presented as a series of execution phases.

Date	Phase	CrowdProduct / Skillathon Activity	Expected Output
21 Sep	Setup	Finalise challenge framework, application process, communication assets and partner roles	Challenge framework ready
22 Sep	Soft Launch	Open Skillathon 2026 and release the six challenge areas	Applications live
22 Sep onward	Ecosystem Activation	Activate Government, universities, colleges, startup networks, industry and ecosystem partners	Participant & mentor pipeline
22 Sep – 2 Oct	Applications	Student/startup teams select a challenge and submit their proposed solution and pilot approach	Applications received
2 Oct	Application Deadline	Applications close	Final applicant pool
2–3 Oct	Screening	CrowdProduct/partners conduct eligibility and first-level solution screening	Qualified teams

3–10 Oct	Selection & Orientation	Select teams; introduce challenge owners, mentors, pilot expectations and success metrics	Selected cohort + pilot canvas
3–10 Oct	Stakeholder Connect	Teams interact with Government problem owners, industry, academia and potential users	Problem validation
10 Oct – 2 Nov	Development & Pilot Sprint	Teams build prototypes, work with mentors, test assumptions and undertake real-world validation/pilots wherever feasible	Prototype + pilot evidence
3 Nov	Bootcamp	Intensive final mentoring, pitch preparation, impact measurement and demo refinement	Final demo/pitch ready
3-4 Nov	Final Evaluation	Jury evaluates problem understanding, innovation, prototype, validation, feasibility, impact and scalability	Winning/finalist solutions
5 Nov	Skillathon Finale	Winners and leading solutions showcased/recognised during Bengaluru Skill Summit 2026	Winners + pilot showcase

What Happens During the 10 Oct - 2 Nov Development Sprint?

This is the most important part of the programme.

Stage 1 - Problem Validation

Teams meet the relevant Government/industry stakeholders and potential users.

They must demonstrate:

Who has the problem → How serious is it → What happens today → Why does the existing approach fall short?

Stage 2 - Prototype

Teams build rather than merely propose.

Acceptable outputs could include:

Working application | AI agent | Dashboard | WhatsApp/voice solution | Hardware prototype | Workflow automation | Digital platform | Tested service/process model

The principle from the original framework remains:

Don't just tell us what you propose to build. Show us what works.

Stage 3 - Mentor & Stakeholder Validation

Selected teams receive access, where relevant, to:

- Government/problem owner
- Industry/domain mentor
- Academic mentor
- Technology/product mentor
- Potential users
- Datasets/sample information where permissible

The earlier framework already envisaged Government problem-owner interaction together with industry, academic and user/problem-discovery support.

Stage 4 - Pilot / Real-World Testing

Where feasible, teams should test with actual users, institutions or workflows.

The size of the pilot should depend on the challenge rather than prescribing the same number for every team.

A pilot could involve:

20-100 users | One institution | One district | One training centre | One Government workflow | One employer/cohort

Teams should submit **evidence rather than claims**, consistent with the original pilot model.

Stage 5 - Measure

Every team defines:

Baseline → Intervention → KPI → Result → Learning → Next Step

This means that even where a full Government deployment cannot happen within three weeks, the team can demonstrate evidence that its core proposition has been tested.